

Tabloid TECH

People And Events That Grabbed Headlines—For Better Or For Worse

Gamer Buys Virtual Land For \$26,500

In an earlier issue of *Digit*, we mentioned MMORPGs—massively multi-player online role-playing games—and that people actually spend large amounts of real money buying stuff in these virtual worlds.

And now in December last, a 22-year-old Australian gamer, known only by his online gaming moniker—Deathifier—spent \$26,500 (Rs 11,63,000) on an island that exists only in a MMORPG. He bought his virtual property on an online auction. The virtual island includes a gigantic

abandoned castle and beautiful beaches, which are “ripe for developing beachfront property.”

The game in question is *Project Entropia*, which allows gamers to directly buy and sell virtual items using real money. Players of other titles often use eBay to sell their virtual stuff.

Deathifier's move is not totally for the fun of it, though—he will make money from his investment, since he can now tax other gamers who come to what is now his land, to mine for gold or hunt.

McNealy Thinks Submarine Is Computer

At a keynote address at the Oracle OpenWorld show, in front of an audience of thousands, Sun CEO Scott McNealy mistook a submarine for a computer.

What happened was, McNealy displayed a pic suppos-

edly from “Popular Mechanics” magazine, here on the left, depicting “how people in 1954 envisioned the home computer.” His point, of course, was to show how far we’ve advanced beyond that.

Here's the goof-up: the photograph he used is a doctored picture of a modern nuclear submarine control room.

You have to give McNealy credit, though, for his scepticism: he asked, “Being from Detroit, I have to wonder: what is the steering wheel for?” So he wasn't entirely fooled, you see.



Nanotech For Britney

On December 14, Britney Spears, in mid-air, decided to put her feet up and kicked off her shoes. Literally. But, she was

hostess, then three or four others complained.”

Nanotechnology may hold hope for Ms Spears. Based in Pennsylvania in the US,



Don't take those shoes off, please!

reportedly asked to put them back on because her feet were smelling.

A passenger aboard the same flight told British tabloid *The Sun*: “The smell was unbelievable. One woman had a word with the air

NanoHorizons has begun selling a line of metallic nanoparticles that kill odour-causing microbes and can be incorporated into socks. The socks should be out in about a year. Till then, she will just have to keep her shoes on!

The Queen's Pudding On eBay

A worker at Buckingham Palace has been sacked for trying to sell a Christmas pudding gift from Queen Elizabeth on—you guessed it—eBay. Ben Church, 25, who worked as a property administrator at the palace, was dismissed

after royal officials learned he had put the pudding from luxury food store Fortnum & Mason for sale on eBay, the *Daily Mirror* reported December 17.

Church put the pudding up for a measly £20 (\$39)—a disgrace for a Royal Pudding.

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